

Runway Debut

India is set to get air taxis by 2026, which will cut down commute times in cities significantly, and provide respite from traffic woes

BY RICHA SHARMA

22 | **▶ IMAGINE EVADING THE** peak-hour traffic of Bengaluru and covering the 35-km odd stretch from the airport to the centre of the city in under 10 minutes. Or imagine spending just seven minutes to travel to Gurugram from Connaught Place in Delhi, where driving takes somewhere between one and one and a half hours. This could be a reality soon—in fact in around two years' time—when air taxis are set to be introduced in the country. They will cut down commuting times significantly, revolutionising the experience.

InterGlobe Enterprises, the parent company of leading airline operator IndiGo,

TAKING FLIGHT

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and US-based Archer Aviation have tied up to launch an all-electric air taxi service in India by 2026.

Archer Aviation will provide 200 electric Vertical Take-off and Landing (eVTOL) aircraft, each capable of carrying four passengers and a pilot, at an approximate cost of \$1 billion.

Also in the fray is a Chennai-based start-up, The ePlane Company, operating under Ubifly Technologies. It announced the launch of eVTOL aircraft by March 2025.

The European Union Aviation Safety Authority has prepared rules for eVTOL aircraft.

But what will be the cost of such rides? Archer Aviation said the Connaught Place-Gurugram trip would cost about ₹2,000-3,000, as opposed to ₹500 in app-based taxi services for the 30-kilometre journey. The initial target audience will be commuters in Delhi, Mumbai and Bengaluru.

According to The ePlane Company, it will take only 14 minutes to reach a place that takes about 60 minutes by car and a short-duration trip (30-40 minutes) is expected to be twice the cost of an app-based taxi ride. Founder and CEO Satya Chakravarthy says that it will take a couple of years to get approval from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA). Archer Aviation is also awaiting certification from US regulator Federal Aviation Administration. After that, it will seek safety clearance from the DCGA.

Globally, several countries are looking at air taxis. China-based Guangzhou EHang Intelligent Technology Co. Ltd has been able to secure a type certificate for the airworthiness of an eVTOL taxi service.

As more and more players look to venture into this new mode of travel, commuters can hope for smoother, faster rides. **BT**



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